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Wild Broom Or, The Flower of the Desert

(*Canti*, xxxiv)

GIACOMO LEOPARDI

(*Translated by Steven J. Willett*)

To Christopher Willett

Καὶ ἠγάπησαν οἱ ἄνθρωποι μᾶλλον τὸ σκότος ἢ τὸ φῶς
And men loved darkness rather than the light
—John, III:19



Here on the arid spine
of the formidable mountain,
destroyer Vesuvius,
brightened by no other tree or flower,
you scatter round your lonely bushes,
fragrant broom,
content in the desert. I once saw your

stalks adorn the desolate regions
 that encircle the City
 that was mistress of mortals in its time,
 and with their grave and silent aspect
 fashion proof and memory for the passer-by
 of that lost empire.
 Now I see you again on this soil, of sad
 and world-abandoned places a lover
 and constant companion of harsh fate.
 These fields strewn
 with barren ash, and heaped
 with hardened lava,
 which resounds under the feet of the traveler;
 where snakes nest and coil in the sun
 and where the rabbit returns
 to its accustomed cavernous burrow;
 once there were rich towns and planted fields,
 golden with grain, and resonate
 with the lowing of cattle;
 once there were gardens and royal palaces,
 for the leisure of the powerful
 welcome retreats; once there were famous cities,
 which the proud mountain with the torrents
 fulminating from its fiery mouth destroyed
 with all their people. Now everywhere
 ruin envelops all
 where you root, O gentle flower, and, as if
 commiserating with others' loss, send to heaven
 a perfume of sweetest fragrance
 that consoles the desert. To this wasteland
 let those who are wont to exalt with praise
 our condition come and see, and witness
 how much all-loving Nature
 cares for our race. They can also estimate
 with a just measure
 the power of humankind,
 which the harsh nurse, when least expected,

with a slight motion in a moment annuls
a part, and can with a motion
barely less slight, in an instant
annihilate utterly.
Depicted on these hills
are the human race's
"Magnificent and progressive fate."

Look here and see your reflection,
proud and foolish century,
you who have abandoned the path marked
till now by resurgent thought,
and turned your steps backward,
boasting of a reversion
you call progress.
At your childish babbling all the thinkers,
whose evil fate made you their father,
go about flattering you, though
at times, among themselves,
they make you a laughingstock. I'll not
descend to my grave with such shame;
but rather the contempt that I harbor
for you in my heart
I'll show as openly as possible,
though I know that oblivion
crushes those who denounce their own age.
But this evil, which we'll share
in common, I've mocked enough.
You're dreaming of liberty, and once again you want
to make a slave of thought, that thought
by which alone we rise in part
from barbarism, and by which alone
civilization flourishes, which alone
guides our common destiny to the noblest end.
So you regret the truth
of the harsh fate and the depressed place
that Nature has assigned us. Therefore you

cowardly turn your back on the light
 that made it manifest; and, in flight, you call
 him who pursues that light vile, and only
 him magnanimous
 who, mocking himself or others, astutely or foolishly,
 exalts the human state above the stars.

A man of modest condition and infirm limbs
 who is generous and noble of soul
 doesn't call or vaunt himself
 rich in possessions or physically strong,
 makes no foolish show
 of a luxurious life or an elegant
 appearance among the crowd;
 but destitute of power and wealth
 he lets himself appear unashamed and calls things,
 speaking frankly, by their true name
 and rates his own affairs as they fit truth.
 I do not of course believe
 him a magnanimous creature, but stupid
 who, born to die and nurtured in pain,
 says: "I am made for joy"
 and with his fetid pride
 fills pages promising an exalted destiny on earth and new
 happiness, which heaven ignores completely,
 much less this world,
 to people whom a breaker
 of the tempestuous sea, a breath
 of malignant air, a subterranean tremor
 destroys so utterly, that scarcely
 a memory of them survives.
 A noble nature is one that
 dares to raise its mortal eyes against
 our common fate and with honest words,
 detracting nothing from truth,
 admits the evil that has been given us as our lot,
 our low and frail state;

a nature that shows itself
 brave and strong in suffering, nor with fraternal
 anger and wrath, still more grievous
 than other injuries, swells
 its miseries, reproaching mankind
 for its own sorrow, but lays the blame
 on *Her* who is truly guilty, who is a mother
 of mortals in birth and a stepmother in Will.
 He calls *Her* the enemy; and against *Her*
 believing the human race to be united,
 as is true, and ranked in opposition from old,
 he judges as his confederates
 all men, and embraces all
 with true love, offering
 and expecting powerful and prompt aid
 in the changing dangers and hardship
 of the common war. And believes it foolish
 to arm one's own hand with human wounds
 and set snares or traps for neighbors, just as on the battlefield
 surrounded by enemy forces, in the most ferocious
 tumult of the assault,
 forgetting the enemy, to incite
 bitter disputes with friends,
 to scatter them in flight and strike with swords
 among their own forces.
 Such thoughts as these
 when revealed openly, as once they were, to the crowd;
 and when that horror
 against malevolent Nature that first
 drew men into a network of solidarity,
 then partial renewal may come
 from true wisdom, the honest and upright
 intercourse of citizens,
 and justice and piety will take another root
 than foolish pride,
 on which foundation the people's probity
 may stand in such stability

as anything can stand that rests on error.

Often on these hills,
desolate wastes clothed in brown
by the hard lava flow, which still seems to ripple,
I sit at night; and on the sad land
I see the stars flaming from the heavens
in purest azure,
and far off reflecting them
the sea, and all the world glittering with sparks
in its circuit through the serene void.
And then when I fix my eyes on these lights,
which appear to be mere points,
and yet are immense, so that
earth and sea are a point to them
in appearance; to whom
not only man but this
globe, where man is nothing,
are completely unknown; and when I gaze
at those still more endlessly remote,
knots almost of stars,
which to us seem like mist, to whom not only man
and earth, but the totality
of our stars, infinite number and mass,
together with the golden sun,
are either unknown or appear as
another earth to them, a point
of nebulous light: in my thoughts
what then do you seem like, o children
of men? Remembering
your state here below, that bears its mark
on the ground I tread; and on the other hand,
that you judge yourself appointed master and end
of All; and how often
you like to tell fantastic fables that, to this obscure
grain of sand with the name of earth,
at your call the authors of universal creation

descend and often converse
delightfully with you; and renewing these absurd
illusions, you insult the wise
down to the present age, although in knowledge
and social customs
it seems to surpass all others; what emotion then,
o wretched humanity, or what thought
facing you finally assails my heart?
I don't know if laughter or pity prevails.

As a small apple falling from a tree
in late autumn
ripeness strikes the ground by its own force,
an ant community's sweet homes,
tunneled in the soft earth
with great labor, and all the works
and the wealth that the industrious race
by long labor had with practice
stored providentially in the summer,
crushes, annihilates and expunges
in a moment; so swooping down from above,
hurled out the thundering womb
to the heights of heaven,
a night and ruin
of ashes, pumice and stones mixed
with boiling streams,
or plunging down the mountainside
furious over the grass
an immense flood
of liquid masses
and metals and searing sand,
left the cities on the farthest shores
washed by the sea ravaged
and obliterated and covered
in a few moments; so that now the goats
graze over them, and new cities
rise over the lava's casing, whose footstool

rests on the buried ones, and whose fallen walls
 the cruel mountain seems to trample underfoot.
 For the seed of man Nature
 has no more regard or care
 than for the ant: and if the one suffers
 less slaughter than the other,
 that only happens because
 its race is more fecund than man.

Fully one thousand eight hundred
 years have passed since those thriving cities,
 oppressed by the fiery force, vanished,
 and now the peasant intent
 on his vineyards, which the dead and scorched soil
 barely nourishes in these fields,
 still glances upward
 suspicious of the fatal
 summit, which is no gentler than ever,
 still sits there tremendous, still threatens
 destruction to himself, his children and their meager
 property. And often
 the poor man lying on the roof
 of his rustic house, beneath the vagrant
 breezes, sleepless all through the night,
 and jumping up frequently, explores the course
 of the dreaded boiling fire, which pours
 from its inexhaustible womb
 down the sandy ridge and casts reflections
 on the Bay of Capri
 the port of Naples and the coast of Mergellina.
 And if he sees it approaching or if in the depth
 of the household well he ever hears the boiling
 water gurgle, he wakes his children,
 he wakes his wife in haste and fleeing with whatever
 of their possessions they can snatch,
 sees in the distance his dear
 nest, and the small field

that was their only defense against hunger,
fall prey to the blazing flood,
crackling as it comes, and inexorably
spreads over all this forever.
After its ancient oblivion, extinct
Pompeii returns to the light of heaven,
like a buried skeleton, which from its grave
avarice or piety hands back to the open air;
and from its deserted forum
directly through the rows
of ruined columns the traveler
contemplates the distant splintered peak
and the smoking summit,
which still threatens the scattered ruins.
And in the horror of the secret night
through the vacant theaters,
the deformed temples and shattered
houses, where the bat hides her brood,
like an ominous torch
that circles through the halls of empty palaces,
the glow of the murderous lava runs,
which reddens the shadows from afar
and dyes all the surrounding regions.
Thus, indifferent to man and the ages
he calls antique, and to the progression
that creates ancestors and descendants,
Nature remains eternally green, proceeding instead
through so long a route
she seems stationary. Meanwhile empires fall,
people and languages pass by: she doesn't see:
and man claims the right of immortality.

And you, gentle broom,
who adorn this despoiled countryside
with fragrant thickets,
you too will soon succumb to the cruel power
of the subterranean fire,

which returns to the place
 it already knows, to stretch over your soft copses
 its voracious tongue. And you'll bow
 beneath its mortal flow without a struggle
 your innocent head:
 but a head not bent in vain
 cowardly begging before
 a future oppressor; nor raised
 with insane pride to the stars,
 nor above the desert,
 where your home and birthplace were
 not through choice but chance:
 far wiser and much less
 fallible than man, since you never believed
 that your frail species
 could, by fate or yourself, become immortal.

NOTE

Leopardi wrote "La Ginestra" in 1836 while staying in the Villa
 Ferrigni at Torre del Greco on the slope of Mt. Vesuvius. It's his
 longest poem and a Summa of his life as a poet and philosopher. He
 died June 14, 1837 (aged 38), in Naples. "La Ginestra" was pub-
 lished posthumously in the 1845 edition of *I Canti*.

I would like to thank Alan Shaw for his help with the translation.
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